



Story Header



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Chapter Fifty-Seven

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TITUS

I find a woman slouched beneath a tree in the open field as I drag my sled on frostless ground, looking as if she's relinquished her life to join the landscape.

Sylvia shrugs, and so I kick her boot, startling her.

"What are you doing here?" I ask her, discovering that her eyes run with tears. The trek has taken so much out of all the survivors of the Afterlife's great attempt at liquidation: noticing her face worn with the same brand of strain, I ask, "are you one of us that has nowhere to go?"

"I was just trying to get away," she says. "If I wasn't so indebted to my past, I might head south with the both of you."

"So you're not?" Sylvia asks. "Are you from here? We didn't know there was as town."

"This is Gaffesend," she says. "And you're headed for Northaven?"

"Whatever is left of it," I say. It's strange enough to mention a place that's been dead in my mind since birth.

I open my rucksack, withdrawing an old book printed in Blackwater's crimson ink. I quickly realize my grandfather's map is no longer useful.

I nudge Sylvia. "We're certainly far past Everett's bounds."

"And who are you?" The girl interrupts.

"The daughter of Khiras," Sylvia says. The words give me a scare when we agreed to keep that truth in confidence, but both of them smile.

"And I'm the queen of England," the girl says.

"Where's England?" I ask.

She looks afraid: struck with the same expression I wore moments earlier. "Too far to measure," she says. "My name's Katiya, and I am . . . or was, a Royal Guard."

"We used to be Royal Guards just like you," Sylvia says: already making friends without hesitation as she lifts Katiya to her feet.

"What did it in for you?" Katiya asks.

I try my own attempt at revelatory humor. "We blew up a mountain," I say.

"So that was you," Katiya says. "Ryder said there was some awful stuff going on up there, but I thought it was just exaggerating."

The name halts me. "What Ryder?"

She shrugs. "You surely wouldn't know him: he's been here for a long time." A silence hangs between us as Katiya decides to part from the old tree, on a spot rife with an energy of dead Essence. "Say . . . if you're passing through, I have a place you can stay for a while."

"Really?" Sylvia asks.

"It's not for long," Katiya says, stricken with an air of remorse. "But rules don't really apply to me all that much anymore. If I can't protect, I can at least house."

"That would be great," I tell her, searching for a blank corner of my grandfather's map to add the first set of strokes since his passing: the first record of a land beyond the wall. "Just give us a place."